

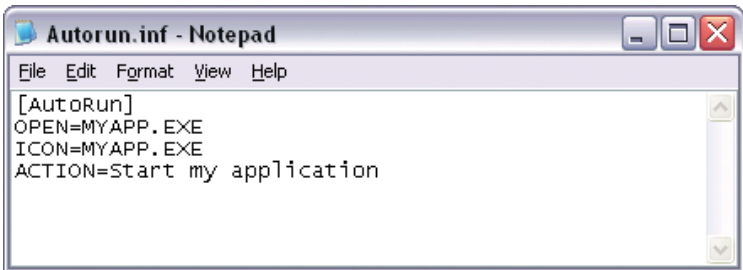
processor speed, RAM sizes and hard disk sizes, all of them minuscule in comparison to the offerings today.

If you uttered the word 'Linux' among your peers, there'd be many a raised eyebrow. Not many had heard of Linux or ISO images. Even fewer had burnt it on disks and booted from it. That's how unrecognised it was.

What made Linux adopters try it?

Back then, Windows XP was popular, and this popularity made it the perfect target for virus writers. Since internet penetration was low, they used pen drives and CDs to transfer harmful worms. Lack of broadband meant that (very) few of us could actually update our anti-virus software.

One little mistake and your PC would slow down to a crawl. All you were left with then was one option – wasting another four hours reinstalling the OS and all your precious software. Because PCs running Windows were so vulnerable, this process may have to be repeated quite a few times pushing users to the point of desperation. It was around this time that many of them decided to try out Linux. And never went back.



Little file, big troubles. Courtesy: Windows XP

One of the Linux's most popular virtues back then was that 'it does not get infected with viruses'. While that's mildly untrue, in a Windows-dominated landscape, it held the value of truth. The problem with carrying the 'virus-free' badge around was that people expected Linux to be just another version of Windows XP, but one that didn't get infected with viruses. A smaller portion of people tried out Linux to simply test a new alternative and see if it worked the way they liked. Once again, users were looking for an operating system that was similar to Windows.